

The Internal Critic

40 min · November Week 1

OBJECTIVE	Students name their internal critic, identify its three tactics, and write their first Compassionate Witness sentence.
CASEL FOCUS	Self-Awareness: understanding the internal critic · Self-Management: introducing the Compassionate Witness
SCENARIO CARDS	None — the Internal Critic Profile worksheet is the primary activity
QUICK REVIEW	1–2 min: "Last unit: we named who you are. Today we start Unit 2 — and we're going to meet a voice you already know very well. Before anything else: what was your biggest takeaway from Unit 1?" Take 2 quick answers. "Today we start listening to the voice inside that judges everything you do."

LEGAL · PPRA NOTE

PPRA Designation — All standard opt-out protocols apply. This lesson is PPRA-designated. All standard opt-out protocols apply. NEVER ask students to share their critic's specific words with the whole class. Journal first — always. Brief counselor before delivery.

SAFETY CHECK

NEVER ask students to share their critic's specific words with the whole class. Journal first — always. After journaling, pairs may share at their own discretion only. Whole-class sharing of internal critic content is not appropriate at any point in this lesson. Students who describe a critic voice that sounds like a specific person may be surfacing trauma. Note privately for counselor follow-up.

ANCHOR CHART · THE INTERNAL CRITIC — THREE TACTICS + COMPASSIONATE WITNESS

Draw this **before class**. Add the Compassionate Witness column during Step 3. **CATASTROPHISING:** "Everything is ruined. This is the worst thing that has ever happened." **GLOBALISING:** "I always fail. I never get it right. I am just bad at this." **PERSONALISING:** "Everything that went wrong is my fault." **COMPASSIONATE WITNESS** (added in Step 3): Honest + Fair + Kind. Not a cheerleader. Not a critic in disguise.

OPENING · 3 MINUTES

"We all have a voice inside that comments on everything we do. When you make a mistake, it has something to say. When you compare yourself to others, it has something to say. Today we are going to look at that voice — not to fight it, but to understand it."